

**Unit 1, Option D,
Topic D7: Politics,
Presidency and
Society in the USA,
1968-2001**

The focus of this topic is on the domestic history of the United States in the last third of the 20th century, addressing social, political and economic issues but not foreign policy except in terms of its domestic impact. Since the focus of Unit 1 is on broad themes, questions will not be set which concentrate exclusively on depth of knowledge, for example about one particular individual or event, other than those which are specifically listed in the content bullet points. Students will, however, be expected to demonstrate their understanding of the themes defined in the content bullet points by the selection and deployment of relevant information as exemplification.

Collectively, the four content bullet points offer a framework for understanding the themes of the exercise of power and the influence of ideology on decision making and the exercise of power. The bullet points cannot be taken in complete isolation from one another and students should develop an appreciation of links between them. For example, a question on race relations would straddle bullet points 2, 3 and 4.

The first bullet point relates to the salient political developments surrounding the presidency and affecting the power of the office of president in these years. Students should be aware of the reasons for Nixon's victories in 1968 and 1972 and why Watergate became an important constitutional issue and the reasons for his resignation in 1974. They should understand why Carter triumphed in 1976 but lost to Reagan in 1980 and why Reagan achieved such popularity, winning a second term by a large margin in 1984. They should understand why his successor served only one term, losing to Clinton in 1992, and why Clinton achieved such popularity. Students will not face question on congressional elections but should be aware of the effects of such elections on presidential power.

The second bullet point relates to social issues and their impact on politics. Students should understand why issues of feminism, religious belief, abortion and gay rights achieved such political prominence, and the continuing issue of race and race relations. They should understand the importance of the Supreme Court with regard to these issues and the ways in which it, in consequence, became a political battleground. Questions will not be set which focus exclusively and specifically on events or individuals not given in the specification, but students should be able to provide exemplification when addressing the impact of these issues.

The third bullet point relates to popular culture and how far popular culture was oppositional over this period. Students should have some understanding of salient developments in popular music, films, television and radio, appreciating the importance of the latter in many localities. They should have some understanding of popular sports and the celebrity culture it engenders and the possible impact of these developments on race relations.

The fourth bullet point relates to the debate over economic policies and the correct role of the state. Students should understand the reaction to enhanced federal spending that developed in the 1970s, the new emphasis on the virtues of lower taxes and free market ideas associated with the Reagan presidency, and the congressional resistance to Democrat initiatives under Clinton in the 1990s.